

Chapter 3

Non-verbal communication: meanings without words

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Non-verbal communication

The average person actually speaks words for a total of only 10 to 11 minutes daily – the standard spoken sentence taking only about 2.5 seconds. In a normal two-person conversation, the verbal components carry less than 35 per cent of the social meaning of the situation; more than 65 per cent of the social meaning is carried on the nonverbal band.

(Knapp 1992, p. 15)

Terms used in non-verbal communication theory

In this chapter and in any further reading you might undertake on non-verbal communication, you will come across different terms to denote the actual activity involved.

Non-verbal behaviour refers to an activity that is not intended as communication. Scratching, blinking or tie-loosening are activities that may or may not convey evidence of nervousness, and it may be premature to assume they do. What is clear is that these activities are present in one person and are part of our way of identifying him or her.

Non-verbal cues or *signals* signify attitudes and information in relationship with verbal communication. They may or may not be purposeful, but they do attract interpretation and meaning. Smiling, laughing, open-handed gestures: these cues may accompany a speech of welcome.

Non-verbal messages stand alone; they are understood within the culture in which they are expressed. They contain structure, code and content. They are intentional or purposeful. Signaling is the best example, but other examples include Morse code and systems of badges or stripes on uniforms to indicate rank or status, used within organisations such as the police or the army.

Non-verbal communication, then, is the sharing of meaning between two or more parties without recourse to words. Non-verbal communication may exist in the *speaker* (dressed in black for a funeral, wearing a university tie, wearing a false beard, or laughing out loud), it may exist in the *receiver* (looking bored, expressing resentment, or sitting forward clapping continuously), or it may exist in the *setting* as perceived by an onlooker (a crowded, noisy shopping centre at lunchtime, a nightclub with deafening music and flashing lights, a hushed radio-station studio or a cathedral during a Sunday morning service).

If, as Knapp has it, 65 per cent of social meaning is carried by non-verbal cues, clearly we must do our best to understand how this relates to our attempts to communicate ideas, opinions and policies, and our attempts to understand and evaluate the ideas, opinions and policies of those with whom we communicate.

How does non-verbal communication relate to verbal communication?

An immediate question to ask is: What functions does non-verbal communication have in a verbal interaction, such as an interview, a public speech or a conversation? The following functions probably cover the field.

1 To reinforce and complement

Non-verbal communication emphasises or reinforces a part of the verbal message. We may nod when we are saying that we agree, or speak with a serious tone about something important, bang our fist on the table to demonstrate anger and frustration, or smile when telling a funny story.

2 To contradict

Non-verbal communication can contradict if non-verbal cues do not match what is spoken (or written). In other words, non-verbal communication may not support verbal messages. For example, you might say, 'I've got time to see you', but the way you glance at your watch contradicts the verbal message.

3 To regulate or repeat

We use gestures, facial expressions, tone of voice and pauses to signal our desire to control the flow of verbal messages. We might throw up our hands to stop the other person speaking, or purse our lips and lean forward hoping to 'get a word in edgeways'. People use eye contact, gestures and pauses to regulate taking turns in a conversation. Saying 'no' can be repeated by a vigorous shaking of the head.

4 To substitute

Entertainers such as Marcel Marceau and Rowan Atkinson (Mr Bean) interpret a range of human emotions and actions without uttering one word. Part of the humour of these characters comes from our ability to fill in their silences. In a group of conversationalists there will be at least one person who speaks little but indicates agreement, support or rejection of other people's ideas with head, eye or arm and hand movements, or other non-verbal cues.

But which of the two, verbal or non-verbal communication, is the more powerful? Most professionals are keenly aware that they must choose and use language well – both spoken and written. Yet non-verbal communication is very powerful and should not be underestimated.

Mehrabian's formula states that for the communication of attitudes the loading is: 7 per cent verbal cues, 38 per cent vocal cues (i.e. paralanguage, or how the words are said), 55 per cent facial cues (Mehrabian, 1981, p. 77).

In other words, your attitude as a professional, whether positive, negative or neutral, is communicated more by *how* you said your message than the actual words you use.

Myths about non-verbal communication

Knapp (1992) warns against some of the myths surrounding the subject of non-verbal communication. This warning is appropriate as many professed 'experts' function in the persuasive marketplace, offering quick advice on how we can use non-verbal codes or formulae to take advantage of clients or rivals. Knapp identifies the following three myths.

1 The isolation myth

This myth tries to make us study non-verbal communication in isolation from the total system of human communication. In fact, Knapp insists, verbal and non-verbal systems are heavily interrelated and interdependent.

2 The key to success myth

This myth assures us that an understanding of the secret codes of non-verbal behaviour will make us successful salespersons or managers. That is, with this knowledge we will be able to 'read' others. In fact, Knapp argues, people are very much aware of their non-verbal behaviour, and can control and adapt it to prevent others from 'breaking the code'.

3 The single meaning myth

This myth asserts that we can 'read' the meaning of a nod, a folding of the arms, or a sprawling posture in a chair. In fact, like verbal symbols, non-verbal movements may have different meanings depending on their social context, the personal mannerisms of the communicator, and, of course, cultural differences.

Relationships conveyed by non-verbal communication

Relating non-verbal to verbal cues is one important dimension of our study. Another is to classify non-verbal cues in terms of the relationships they help to construct between people. Mehrabian (1981) expresses surprise that there is so much consensus within and even between cultures about the use and understanding of 'nonverbal and vocal signals when, unlike language, such matters are hardly ever explicitly discussed or taught' (p. iv). He lists three separate dimensions of study and research in such 'implicit communication' (chapters 1–3):

- 1 cues used to communicate pleasure–displeasure, especially liking and disliking, and degrees of evaluation
- 2 cues used to communicate arousal–nonarousal, especially high or low responsiveness to others
- 3 cues used to communicate dominance or submissiveness, especially the extent to which one is controlling or controlled by another person.

These three dimensions are useful general categories and we shall refer to them in the discussion that follows. Before reading on, consider some of the non-verbal cues you have experienced or used yourself to convey the three kinds of relationships or attitudes listed.



Eyes regulate the flow of communication.

Classifying the systems of non-verbal communication

Non-verbal communication comprises five major interacting systems:

- *kinesics* (body language) concerns eye behaviour, facial expression, gesture and posture and personal appearance
- *proxemics* concerns the use of space, distance and territory for purposes of meaning
- *chronemics* concerns communication by time
- *haptics* concerns communication by touch
- *vocalics* concerns communication by sounds other than words, and is also known as *paralanguage*.

Kinesics: visual communication

Eye behaviour

Most people agree that eye behaviour is one of the most powerful means of non-verbal communication. In Western culture there is a tradition that the eyes are the 'windows of the soul'. In nearly all cultures terms equivalent to 'the evil eye' or 'the divine eye' can be found. It is not surprising then that Westerners tend to believe that eye-contact avoidance denotes shiftiness and deviousness. Westerners tend to respect people who 'look you in the eye'. The eyes not only identify us, they are also seen to communicate most directly on our behalf.

Eyes regulate the flow of communication. Seeking eye contact with a colleague at a party informs her that you wish to speak to her. In a different situation you may wish to use your eyes to signal that you are not receptive. So if the lecturer is staring around the room wanting to pick on someone to solve a difficult statistics problem, the best way to avoid being called upon is to look away.

In conversation, eye contact provides signals for turn-taking. We may be looking away from our colleague while we are speaking, and when coming to the end of our utterance we may glance at him to indicate it is his turn to speak.

How long should you look at people's eyes when conversing with them? One researcher on Western communication reactions has produced the following statistics.

In a typical two-person conversation, people look at each other about 61 per cent of the time, and their gaze coincides (mutual gaze) about 31 per cent of the time. Mutual gaze lasts on the average only about one second, while each individual gaze is usually about three seconds long. The same person will look more when listening (75 per cent of the time) than when speaking (41 per cent of the time).

(Forgas 1996, p. 157)

We are not suggesting you set out to measure your own eye-contact activity, but if the above statistics are valid for Western contexts, they suggest that there is an implicit set of rules by which we moderate our polite interactions. This is part of any culture.

In a lecture or a public address to a professional group it is normal, and advisable, for the speaker to distribute eye contact fairly evenly around the audience, scanning the room for non-verbal cues of interest, uncertainty or boredom. In turn, the audience are expected to look at the speaker most of the time. If they don't, the speaker may feel that either the material or its presentation is in need of revision.

We might summarise the communicative functions of 'eye-behaviour' as follows:

- to indicate degrees of attentiveness, interest and arousal
- to help initiate and sustain relationships
- to influence attitude-change and persuasion
- to regulate interaction
- to communicate emotions
- to define power and status relationships.

Facial expression

The second important study in kinesics is facial expression and appearance. Providing information about emotion would seem to be the most important function of the face in communication. It has been estimated that the face is capable of creating 250 000 expressions (Ruben 1992, p. 158), and we all learn to read not only the obvious emotion being conveyed by our companion, but also more subtle, perhaps contradictory, feelings.

The face communicates value judgements about things and people. It communicates interest or lack of interest in other people or in the activities going on around us. It indicates the degree of our interest or involvement in a situation.

But just as importantly the face communicates the amount of control we have over our emotions. In business situations we often 'mask' our facial expressions. Watch a salesperson diplomatically handling a fractious customer, or a public speaker subject to abusive shouts from the audience and maintaining a cool demeanour.

Ekman & Friesen (1984) claim that it is fairly easy for people to 'put on a false face', thus limiting the power of non-verbal cues of this kind. They refer to three techniques: qualifying, modulating and falsifying.

- *Qualifying* may involve adding another facial expression to the original, in order to modify the impact. For example, a boss who gives a subordinate a look of surprise, immediately followed by a look of concern, may be trying to modify the impact of initial amazement by switching to a questioning mode to find out more details.
- *Modulating* occurs when the intensity of the facial expression is changed to communicate stronger or weaker feelings than those actually being experienced. For example, you may communicate slight surprise, facially, when you feel quite shocked.
- *Falsifying* may mean showing facial emotion when no emotion is felt, or masking emotion with a blank expression.

For professionals, the point is that facial expressions can be difficult to interpret accurately. Be sensitive to the needs of your colleagues and try to develop your awareness of the meanings of non-verbal cues such as facial expression. A bit of dissimulation can of course be beneficial. The advice given in the song 'Put on a Happy Face' can be a good way of getting people to listen and attend when you rise to begin your public speech. It's certainly more advisable than to mount the podium with an expression that mirrors your terror.

Gesture and posture

You might know someone like this: 'If his hands were tied behind his back he couldn't utter a word.' Sometimes such people use gestures that are merely nervous, meaningless movements of the hands and arms. Others use their hands very descriptively. Watching such a person talking in the distance, we may feel we know what he or she is saying without hearing a word.

Similarly, people use posture differently; people sit and stand differently, perhaps because of their levels of interest and confidence.

Gesture and posture are discussed together because it is difficult to imagine one happening without the other. Gestures usually refer to movements of parts of the body, especially the hands and arms, while posture refers to the disposition of the whole body. In public speaking we may move quickly from one gesture to another but retain a fairly stable posture. Or we may lean forward from a relaxed sitting position, stare fixedly at our companion and make chopping signs with our right hand to drive home a point we wish to make.

Leathers (1997, p. 80) discusses functional (positive) and dysfunctional (negative) uses of bodily cues: gestures and posture. He makes some value judgements that he believes are fairly generally agreed on in Western social contexts. What do you think?

- 1 Bodily cues that communicate a sense of openness and confidence are desirable. Examples are individuals who 'unbutton their coats, uncross their legs, and move up towards the edge of the chair'. In contrast, crossed arms, crossed legs and related gestures often communicate inaccessibility and defensiveness. Hand-to-face gestures, like covering the mouth, and nose- and head-scratching, are signals that the communicator lacks confidence or is tense.
- 2 Nervous gestures take many forms and are usually unintentional. We all get nervous at times but there may be ways to control our nerves by not allowing them to issue in unintentional non-verbal cues. Twiddling, fiddling and fidgeting, or any extraneous movement that serves no purpose, will probably be interpreted by our audience as signs of nervousness. Tugging at clothes or ears, playing with objects on the table – these all communicate 'I lack confidence in what I'm saying'.

Personal appearance

Here, we offer some general guidelines on personal appearance. These are essentially conservative. Generally, experience suggests that you dress according to the culture of those you are meeting with, i.e. meet their dress expectations (considering their age, education, class, gender, ethnicity and region). Clothing and jewellery should not be markedly different in quality or level of sophistication from the same items worn by your respondents.

Dark-coloured, conservative clothing will aid credibility, whereas lighter clothing enhances perceptions of likability and friendliness. Dark glasses are undesirable as they hide your eyes and people may distrust you.

Proxemics: spatial communication

The anthropologist E. T. Hall (1969, pp. 110–18) pioneered the study of space and territory as aspects of human interaction. He named the study *proxemics*. Hall claimed that people segment their social life into four zones: intimate, personal, social and public.

He pointed out that these zones or distances applied to 'middle-class, healthy adults, mainly natives of the northeastern seaboard of the United States' and were not necessarily typical of people from other cultures, age-levels or classes.

Intimate zone

The *intimate* zone (0 to 45 centimetres) is reserved for loved ones. Hand-holding, embraces and whispering are important here.

Personal zone

In the *personal* zone (0.45 to 1.2 metres) we interact with friends and acquaintances. There will be more touching and lower vocal volume. Physical contact is possible at the 'close phase' of this zone but there is also a 'small protective sphere or bubble that an organism maintains between itself and others'.

Social zone

In the *social-consultative* zone (1.2 to 3.65 metres) we are at ease with casual acquaintances in interviews, conversations, or, say, card games. Physical contact is not appropriate and business discourse at the far end of this zone has a formal character.

Public zone

In the *public* zone (over 3.65 metres), we interact with strangers in a public place. Lecturers and their students, rock singers and their audiences operate at this level.

Of course, we cannot always control our social distance, especially if we live in cities or work in crowded offices or factories, or go to universities and institutes with huge enrolments. But, as a rule, our behaviour changes according to the social distance we are experiencing.

For example, in a crowded lift, we would be in the intimate zone with strangers; so we may turn away from them, if possible, and avoid eye contact. Sharing a seat in a bus or train, we are again in either the intimate or the personal zone and will probably turn away from the other person or stare ahead avoiding their gaze. If a stranger in either of these situations uses the social distance to be familiar, we are likely to be offended.

Of course, in both these settings we may strike up an acquaintance with the person we are thrown together with. This may happen if we like the look of each other, or if an incident gives us something to discuss (such as a long train delay). But such occasions are the exception rather than the rule.

The manner in which we organise and use space is also a means of communicating non-verbally. The physical distances we create among ourselves are psychologically, socially and culturally determined and have an important effect on communication.

Spatial arrangements communicate information about the way we live and feel. The size of a house or office will communicate something about the wealth or importance of the occupants. Offices on the top floors of buildings are generally considered to be more prestigious than those on lower levels.

We place distance between ourselves and others according to the kinds of relationships we have, or are striving to achieve – particularly in Western cultures. No matter how crowded a bus, train or lift, people always try to keep apart from each other. Even if a railway carriage is practically empty, strangers entering it will occupy seats as far from each other as possible. What constitutes a comfortable personal distance varies greatly from culture to culture, person to person, situation to situation, and depends also on our relationships with the people concerned.

In the office you may also notice peculiarities of positioning. Furniture may be arranged in specific positions to create a particular working atmosphere. People may sit in particular seats around a boardroom table when they are called to meetings. We may have our favourite chair in the coffee room and feel annoyed if someone else occupies it.

Chronemics: time communication

Time is an important consideration in non-verbal communication: how we *use* time, how we *waste* time, how we *make* time up, how we *time* our day, and so on. Be five minutes late for an interview, and your reliability may be questioned. Be ten minutes early, and you may be thought insecure. Turn up on time at a party, and your hosts may think you are too keen to make an impression; be one hour late, and they may be insulted. For social appointments some people keep others waiting to demonstrate power or superior attractiveness. There may be a ‘waiting game’ where people jostle for power in a relationship using time as the weapon. In business, executives sometimes keep visitors waiting to impress them with their importance. In interviews, pausing and silences can be powerful weapons to demonstrate disapproval, superior power or intimidation.

But generally, manipulative power and other games using time are transparent and serve only to undermine the credibility of the game player. In Western culture professional conduct usually favours a fairly conscientious attitude to punctuality, promptness of response and reliability of behaviour. So telephone calls are returned within hours, not days, and without the need for repeat calls. Applicants are in the waiting room five minutes before the appointment time; senior executives don’t keep juniors or visitors waiting without apology for more than a few minutes.

Are there different concepts of time in other cultures? It would appear so. We refer to these later in this chapter and in Chapter 4 on intercultural communication.

Haptics: touch communication

We can communicate a variety of feelings (for example anger, interest, trust, warmth, love or fear) through *tactile communication* (touching), a powerful non-verbal communication signal.

As with eye contact, there are certain accepted patterns of touching behaviour. The degree of touching acceptable in any social group varies according to age, social

situations and cultural background. In some cultures it is accepted behaviour for men to embrace and kiss each other in public, whereas in other cultures such behaviour would arouse disapproval, embarrassment or ridicule.

Parents convey their feelings towards babies in their first months almost solely through touching. It is certainly a powerful form of communication between parents and children; hugs, kisses and tickles are often a more immediate and effective communication channel than mere words. In fact, some of our primary emotions, like love or pity, are communicated through touch.

Touching behaviour is also a matter of individual style and is linked to people's personalities. There are some people for whom touching comes naturally and contributes positively to their effectiveness as communicators. The hand on your shoulder from one individual may be a friendly, reassuring communication signal, whereas the same action from someone else may be interpreted as insincere or presumptuous, or even insulting.

In Western society, touching is subject to implicit norms. Between those who are closely associated, touching is both accepted and expected, but among strangers it is not encouraged. In fact, we all give out non-verbal bodily signals that indicate whether we wish or do not wish to be touched.

Sexual harassment is an important issue in workplace relations today and can occur by inappropriate use of touching as well as by other means of verbal and non-verbal communication. It is wise for everyone in an organisation to read carefully any manuals on sexual harassment and, if in doubt, to ask the appropriate manager for clarification.

Vocalics: sound communication or *paralanguage*

The auditory communication system involves the conscious control of vocal sounds: tone, loudness, pitch, rate, duration, quality, regularity, articulation, pronunciation and silence. *Para* means 'beyond'. So *paralanguage* means aspects of vocal sounds that are non-verbal or 'wordless'. These we discuss in Chapter 9 in relation to formal speech presentation (see 'Using the voice', pp. 236–8) In this chapter we ask you to note the power of non-language aspects of communication in everyday communication.

Tone

We would like to make a special comment on tone at this point. *Tone* refers to the emotion or attitude conveyed to the listener and about the topic. Our tone may be enthusiastic and sincere, or ironic, or sarcastic, or hostile. It will be very bad for sales if our sales staff speak enthusiastically about the product to each other but hesitantly to the customers. It is possible to say the same thing in many different tones, and in the process to convey totally different meanings.

Guidelines for effective auditory communication in professional life can be summarised as follows.

Recommended vocal cues

- 1 In speech presentations or interviews, strive for a conversational speaking rate of 125 to 150 words per minute. For persuasive communication, a moderately fast rate (175 words per minute) has been shown to be effective. Individuals who use a conversational speaking style are viewed as more pleasant, likable and friendly than those who do not.
- 2 Emphasise the most important points you are making with appropriate changes in volume and pitch: the monotonous voice damages credibility. Individuals with a narrow pitch range are viewed as unassertive, uninteresting and lacking in confidence. Variation in rate and pitch will make you appear more dynamic, animated and extroverted.
- 3 Deliberate pauses before the most important points you are making will emphasise your competence and increase the likelihood that what you say will be remembered.

Undesirable vocal cues

- 1 Eliminate non-fluencies such as *ah* or *um*, or incomplete words and sentences. The non-fluent person is usually seen as under-confident, anxious and perhaps incompetent.
- 2 Avoid lengthy pauses before responding to a question; they suggest indecisiveness.
- 3 The excessively loud voice is associated with aggressiveness.
- 4 Try to eliminate or minimise flatness, nasality and tenseness in your voice. These features suggest you are non-dynamic, uninteresting and withdrawn.
- 5 Faulty or sloppy articulation and improper pronunciation have a negative effect on perceived competence.
- 6 Do not speak at over 200 words per minute, as an accelerated speaking rate is associated with an unacceptable level of anxiety.

Non-verbal communication and impression management

Perhaps you may have found the points about non-verbal communication cues interesting, but may be asking what value this knowledge is to you in your work, whether it involves teaching, negotiating, selling, counselling, advertising or managing. Can one change personal non-verbal habits built up over a lifetime?

We all have non-verbal habits or behaviours, developed over time, that might irritate people. Think of your friends, the ones you really care about. List their non-verbal 'faults': those areas of behaviour over which you think they might be able to make some improvements if it were vital to do so.

In communication classes, when students make classroom presentations, we tell them that this may be their last opportunity to have their peers criticise them about

irritating personal habits, such as saying 'um' every three sentences during a speech, tugging at their ear, moving around the podium too much (or not moving at all), failing to look at their audience, or mispronouncing certain keywords.

Perhaps the insights into meaning provided by non-verbal cues might help us manage the impressions we leave on those we have contact with in professional life. If we consider the range of non-verbal behaviours – eye contact, facial expression, dress and appearance, gestures and posture, spatial relations, touching and vocalic or para-language messages – there may be alterations we can make to our behaviour that will help us create positive impressions.

Four image dimensions

Ross (1991) suggests that the impressions we make can be defined by four image dimensions: *credibility*, *likability*, *interpersonal attractiveness* and *dominance*. All these are important to us in any context, but one or more may be predominant in certain contexts. For example, likability may matter most in social situations or in groups working together democratically, dominance most in contexts where power and leadership are in question, and credibility where one's sincerity, competence and trustworthiness are being examined.

Likability is probably as important as credibility in most professional situations. It is related to interpersonal attractiveness, which is more about the impression one makes at the personal rather than the public level. It is about being interesting, emotionally expressive and sociable.

Dominance is about power and assertiveness. Most groups can point to one of their members who has this quality more than the others. Dominance, however, needs to be managed, so as not to appear as arrogance or aggressiveness.

So you need to decide which dimensions are important to your impression management in a particular context and how you might achieve this management.

In a job interview credibility rather than dominance might be valued, so your verbal and non-verbal cues would be aimed at achieving respect for your manner, confidence, sincerity and trustworthiness. For promotion to a partnership, dominance together with likability might need to be emphasised.

Of course, your personality will dictate which of the four principles is most important to you. It may be likability. However, in a particular context likability may be less relevant than credibility. In other words, people may come to like you if they trust your judgements, even though they judge you to be shy and introverted.

Your approach to impression management may be to eliminate negative non-verbal cues, because negatives are often more noticed and criticised than positives.

Note that we are not advocating personality or character change here. Such transformations are impossible anyway (and not desirable). Nor are we encouraging you to be manipulative or insincere. Rather we are suggesting that thought be given to the impression you are making in a specific professional situation, just as you would adjust

your behaviour in a social, family, sporting or religious situation in order to do justice to your qualities.

Certainly we can make poor first impressions through poor non-verbal communication. The problem is that some people give too much weight to the non-verbal. In an interview you may be ruled out because of your accent, hesitant manner, shifty eyes or clammy hands – none of which may reflect the great degree of sincerity, thoughtfulness and sheer hard work you are capable of putting into a job.

Here, then, are some general guidelines for managing non-verbal behaviours to achieve enhanced impression management (Leathers 1997, pp. 203–5). We say *general guidelines* because every social context is different.

Achieving credibility

Professional credibility may be enhanced by:

- maintaining a high level of eye contact with, but not excessive staring at, your partner
- ensuring that verbal and non-verbal messages are consistent
- avoiding insincere smiles (i.e. smiling to impress when smiling is irrelevant to the discussion)
- speaking at a relatively fast rate with short, purposeful pauses, conveying confidence and competence
- avoiding indications of tension, nervousness or fear, such as shifty eyes, lip-moistening, collar-loosening
- meeting the personal appearance expectations of your hosts, colleagues or clients.

In the business or professional world, credibility is an important qualification to achieve. Credibility has three components: competence, trustworthiness and dynamism. Of course, these qualities are judged by what we have done, what we say and write, and how we relate to people. All these qualities are conveyed in a complex mixture of verbal and non-verbal communication.

Achieving likability

Likability is characterised by:

- relaxed behaviour, appropriate touching, forward leaning, sincere smiling and open body positions
- signalling interest, attentiveness and respect, with sustained and direct eye contact
- speaking in a voice that is pleasant, relaxed, emotionally expressive and friendly.

Achieving interpersonal attractiveness

Interpersonal attractiveness is generally associated with:

- behaviours that are spontaneous, disclosing and uncensored
- a high level of responsiveness, with head-nodding, positive vocal reinforcement, direct body-orientation and direct eye-contact

- a choice of seating arrangements that decrease interpersonal distance and increase capacity for visual contact.

Achieving dominance

Dominance may not be an attractive term for this attribute. We don't respond favourably to people who too obviously dominate us. The concept of *leadership* is probably more acceptable. Real leadership and achievement of a dominant position in a group probably requires the perception by others of superior ability, intellect, grasp of situations and trustworthiness. In terms of non-verbal behaviour the dominant person in a group may:

- maintain eye contact with other group members, especially those being addressed or instructed
- control talk time, speak more frequently and more loudly than others
- tend to interrupt others perceived to be off the topic and firmly bring them into line
- reveal very little evidence of hesitancy or doubt
- appear confident, relaxed and direct.

Non-verbal communication in successful interviews

In an interview participants tend to be closer and more intimately connected than in other situations, such as meetings. This may be why research suggests that non-verbal communication is relevant to success in interviews.

One research study (Forbes and Jackson, 1980) tested the success of engineers applying for jobs. They found:

- 1 Eye behaviour was the most reliable indicator of success. Direct eye-contact (rather than gaze avoidance and eye wandering), was much more in evidence among successful applicants than among unsuccessful applicants. Short-term eye-contact suggests lack of self-confidence. Looking directly at the interviewer conveys more assertiveness, confidence and initiative.
- 2 Smiling was also an indicator of success, although insincere smiles were detected easily; frowning was a feature of rejected applicants.
- 3 Head movements, usually in the form of nodding, were also features of the successful applicants.
- 4 High-immediacy behaviour sums up success here. It is characterised as sustained eye-contact, smiling, attentive posture, direct body-orientation, animated gestures and close proximity to the interviewer. On the other hand, what are known as *adaptor gestures*, such as hand-wringing, hand-to-face movements and fidgeting, indicate lack of self-confidence.

This is not to suggest that verbal communication skills are not extremely important in interviews. Researchers fairly consistently find that successful applicants exhibit conciseness of expression, answer questions fully and frankly, and keep to the point.

You may find Exhibit 3.1 useful in evaluating your own or other people's non-verbal cues in a Western context. It applies best perhaps to people's behaviour in an interview or speech presentation.

EXHIBIT 3.1 Common perception of non-verbal cues

Type	Positive	Negative
Eye behaviour	Sustained eye contact	Looking away from questioner when answering Keeping eyes downcast Excessive blinking or eye flutter
Gestures	Relaxed, spontaneous, unrehearsed Related to verbal points made Arms spread expansively out from body	Hand-to-face gestures Throat clutching Fidgeting Tugging at clothes Extraneous head movements
Posture	Open, relaxed Frequent and forceful postural shifts Leaning forward when smiling	Constricted position Body rigidity Crossed arms or legs Arms and hands kept close to body
Voice	Conversational style Appropriate variation in pitch, rate and volume Volume sufficient to convey competence and dynamism	Flat, tense, nasal Too fast, too slow, dull, monotonous Too many pauses 'Ahs'/'ums', repeated words

Intercultural dimensions of non-verbal behaviour

This section should be read in conjunction with Chapter 4 on intercultural communication. Some points may be repeated for emphasis.

As we have emphasised already, non-verbal cues are a powerful influence in interpersonal communication. Not surprisingly, differences in non-verbal communication cues between cultures can nullify well-prepared negotiations, and even destroy developing business relationships. Let us retrace some of the areas already discussed but with intercultural comparisons in mind.

- *Body language:* In some cultures the open body-position (leaning forward with uncrossed arms and legs, arms away from the body) usually suggests acceptance of new ideas. The closed positions include leaning back, hands behind the head, arms and legs crossed or close together, or hands in pockets, suggesting defensiveness, shutting others out. In other cultures there are different habits and expectations for these positions and gestures.
- *Head movements:* Most cultures share the habit of shaking the head for 'no' and nodding the head for 'yes'. But a number have other signs, and not to identify them can be confusing and embarrassing.
- *Facial expression:* Some cultures are demonstrative and expressive; others value the suppression and control of emotion to indicate the desired characteristic of self-control.
- *Eye contact:* Some cultures, like Western contexts, see eye contact as evidence of honesty. The averted gaze may be construed as conveying dishonesty and shiftiness. However, in some other cultures it is considered rude to engage the gaze or stare. Inferiors or juniors lower their eyes in the company of superiors or elders; people of different genders do not make eye contact. On the other hand, in some cultures people in a conversation gaze intently at each other, even regarding the wearing of sunglasses as discourteous.
- *Display of emotion:* In some cultures men do not (usually) cry and women are not encouraged to show anger. In others, anger is never shown in public by anyone; emotional control is considered both polite and dignified.
- *Gestures:* Head nodding and 'thumbs up' signs vary in meaning between different cultures. They should be used very sparingly.
- *Space:* Distance between people interacting in formal and informal situations differs culturally. There can also be differences within cultures (e.g. between men and women, between younger and older people).
- *Touch:* Some claim touching is associated with power: more powerful people touch less powerful people more often than vice versa. The nature and conventions of touching between people of the same sex and people of different sexes can be completely different from culture to culture.

- *Time:* Attitudes to time vary between cultures. In some cultures, punctuality is seen as evidence of dependability. Other cultures act more spontaneously and 'unreliably'. Others act more slowly in negotiations because they wish to get to know the other party better and hesitate to close the deal before they are comfortable with forming a business relationship. Meetings have different lead times in different cultures. In some, two weeks is needed for meeting appointments; in others a date two weeks ahead would be forgotten.
- *Other non-verbal symbols:* Clothing and colours are two other variables in non-verbal communication. In some cultures certain styles and colours of clothing are considered more professional and therefore more credible. In others, clothing is even more prescribed and related to specific occupational groups. For example, university students wear uniforms; company badges are worn to indicate rank within the organisation.

In some cultures, brides usually wear white and mourners wear black. In others, people wear pink or red to weddings and white for mourning. Purple flowers are for the dead, and red ink is used to record deaths, but never to write about the living.

While drawing your attention to some variations in behaviour, we have avoided assigning particular behaviours to specific cultures. This is because of the complexity of cultural norms and customs. In all cultures there will be individual and regional variations, differences between the young and the old, the radical and the conservative, the poor and the wealthy. In countries subject to a lot of immigration and mixing of cultures, like Australia, generalisations about cultural behaviour will be difficult to make, and possibly misleading.

This only makes the task of 'culture reading' more complex and emphasises the need for vigilance and tolerance.

If you travel, you will need to be particularly sensitive to all these codes. But how do you learn about them? There are of course guidebooks on customs. But general advice is to be sensitive to the presence of cultural stereotypes. It is wise to be courteous, polite, respectful and considerate. These qualities will usually translate well in any culture.

Emoticons: non-verbal signs on the computer

When using a computer we cannot hear voice inflection, nor can we see the funny, naughty, or sad emotions of people's faces. So creative Internet users have invented a range of symbols called *emoticons* to denote feeling. Emoticons are a way of denoting emotion when communicating on the Internet: the word *emoticon* is derived from combining the words *emotion* and *icon*. Additionally, acronyms and initialisms are used in

order to save keystrokes and time in conversation and in email. Some examples are LOL (laugh out loud), ROTF (rolling on the floor) and BRB (be right back).

An emoticon dictionary

To understand these emoticons you need to tilt the page to the right so you can see the smiley faces. You will find smiley faces used in chat rooms on the Internet, text-messaging, electronic bulletin board systems, T-shirts and email.

Here are the basic faces:

: -)	= smile	: -D	= laughing smile
: -*	= kiss	; -)	= wink
: -X	= my lips are sealed	: -P	= blahh [slip of the tongue]
: -	= indifferent	: -(	= frown
: '(	= crying	: -o	= oh!
0: -)	= angel	>: ->	= devil
: ->	= biting sarcastic smile	>: ->	= devilish wink

In addition to faces, symbols express emotions and/or actions and commonly used expressions.

Reviewing the issues in non-verbal communication

1 How does non-verbal communication relate to verbal communication?

Non-verbal communication may reinforce the verbal, as in gesture and posture cues, it may communicate the emotional content of the message, or it may contradict what is actually spoken or written.

2 What relationships does non-verbal communication portray in human interaction?

Non-verbal behaviour sets up cues or signals, positive or negative. These cues express or reflect liking or disliking, dominance or submission, and degrees of responsiveness.

3 Which is the more powerful, verbal or non-verbal communication?

In most transactions language is central, and the relative importance of non-verbal cues will vary from one situation to another. How we really feel about an issue is largely conveyed non-verbally, despite what we may say. Ultimately, professionals need to be able to use words and non-verbal cues effectively in their professional work.

4 Is there a 'grammar' or 'code' of non-verbal communication that we can learn, like the Morse code, and use to manipulate people?

Only in the broadest terms, and then only within a cultural and social context. It is better to think of clusters of codes, verbal and non-verbal, that apply in any specific situation and enable the participant to read its non-verbal meanings. Not only would it be inappropriate for anyone to advocate this 'art', it would be unethical for them to practise it.

While the non-verbal operates alongside the verbal it has, however, characteristics different from those of language. It can usually be decoded more immediately and automatically than the verbal. Also, it appears that non-verbal messages are less likely to be stage-managed than verbal messages; that is, they are more likely to be sincere and spontaneous. Thus they can often give the speakers away, revealing attitudes and emotions they may wish to hide.

5 When verbal and non-verbal cues contradict each other, which of the two has the greater credibility?

A number of studies have suggested that the non-verbal message has more credibility than the verbal one, simply because it seems less easy to manipulate than the verbal. The famous lie detector is the classic case. Most people believe the machine; few accept the suspect's protestations of innocence.

Discussion questions and exercises

- 1 Consider the four image dimensions: credibility, likability, interpersonal attractiveness and dominance. Select one of these and explain how you might emphasise it to your advantage in an interview, a speech or a negotiation.
- 2 Test Hall's theory of social distance for yourself. Go among a group of friends or colleagues at a workplace, college or sports gathering, or in a crowd at a shopping centre. Observe the social distances that apply. Write about your observations, especially about any breaking of the rules you note.
- 3 During the next few days, make a study of the eye-contact behaviour of people you encounter in public places. Some settings you might consider are: classrooms, lifts, escalators, footpaths, traffic jams, street crossings, parks, trains, buses and cinema foyers.
- 4 Keep a 'touch diary' for one day of this next week and write up your findings for the group. Consider the touching behaviour of your friends with each other: men and men, men and women, women and women, family members, people of higher and lower status, strangers. Try to decide what feelings are conveyed by what kinds of touching and to what extent touching reinforces, contradicts, regulates or substitutes for verbal communication.
- 5 Make a recording of a television interview or speech and write an analysis of the non-verbal cues used by one or more of the participants. Consider his or her gestures and posture, eye-contact patterns, touching and territorial behaviour, and paralanguage. Make use of Exhibit 3.1 on page 70.
- 6 Imagine you have been asked to write a short manual of 'dos' and 'don'ts' for the use of non-verbal communication in any one of the following situations. Write about 300 words.
 - a conducting an interview to select a new member of staff
 - b making a sales presentation to a small number of potential clients gathered in the company's reception room
 - c being the host of a cocktail party for senior staff and their partners
 - d going to an interview with a senior person in the organisation to ask for a promotion or transfer
 - e conducting a short training course for staff appointed recently
 - f visiting a client of the firm to answer queries raised about one of your firm's products
 - g discussing with a potential new client the services your organisation can offer
- 7 Try presenting the following speech to your group. Take it in turns, adopting different tones: the first speaker could adopt a tone that is enthusiastic and committed; the second, sceptical and ironic; the third, outraged; and the fourth might treat the whole thing as a complete joke.

The boss told us today the firm is to start a new flexitime program next week. The new system would control arrival and finishing times more closely and make sure people were supervised at all times during the day. In return it would give us a guaranteed two days a month off duty, which we would take when it suited the firm.

- 8 Use your knowledge of non-Western cultures to draw attention to differences in non-verbal communication between one or more of these cultures and Western (Australian) culture. Consider especially: eye behaviour, touching, gestures and posture, and social distance.

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